

Photographs by MANDAR DEODHAR



SHINEY AHUJA AT THE OSHIWARA POLICE STATION (LEFT); HIS WIFE ANUPAM AT A PRESS CONFERENCE



The Shine WEARS OFF

The cracks beneath Bollywood's Botoxed façade get an ugly public airing as Shiney Ahuja is accused of rape

By **Kaveree Bamzai**
and **Swati Mathur**

In his first release in 2005, Shiney Ahuja played a Catholic priest who forces a young girl to have sex with him on her wedding night. He calls her to his chamber, flings her on the bed and then forces himself on her. The movie was called, quite appropriately, *Sins*. That scene may well be haunting Ahuja as he shares a cell with 16 others in the Oshiwara police station lock-up, having been arrested after his young domestic help accused him of raping her. This comes soon after Bollywoodians expressed shock and horror over the abduction and rape of actor-director Deepak Tijori's 13-year-old daughter.

The crime Ahuja is accused of is grotesque even by Bollywood's flexible moral standards. When the young girl walked into the police station at 8 p.m. on June 14, the police's first reaction was to dismiss the allegation. When the inconsolable victim and her family persisted, senior officers decided to investigate the matter. Ahuja was taken for questioning from his sixth floor apartment in Tarapore Towers by 9 p.m. and on the same night, the police recorded the victim's

statement and sent her for a medical examination. By midnight, the preliminary medical reports confirmed that rape had occurred. By 4 a.m. the next morning, Ahuja was arrested under IPC Section 376 on charges of rape, Section 342 for wrongful confinement and Section 506 for threatening to kill his victim.

Anupam Pandey, Ahuja's wife of over 10 years who spent much of their married life in New York working as a publicist in an IT firm, has stood by her man, quite publicly, even staging a press conference. She said: "There is only one truth; that Shiney is innocent. I've known him for 15 years. He is a celebrity and a soft target." The police has refused to put this on record, but insist that Ahuja confessed to having raped his help when he was first brought for questioning. None of that though is admissible in court.

It is clear though that the 36-year-old from Delhi, an army officer's son with the right educational back-



“ He confessed to me recently that he didn't have any movies. I've known him and his wife very closely. I can't believe it. ”

ANURAG BASU, DIRECTOR, GANGSTER, LIFE...IN A METRO